OBS Studio Quick Start

Recording Your First Video

Preface

About This Guide

This guide covers installing OBS Studio, building your first scene, and recording a video, plus reference material on output settings and common issues.

This guide is an independent, unofficial quick-start reference and is not affiliated with or endorsed by the OBS Project.

Chapter 1

Scenes and Sources

Topics:

- Installing OBS Studio
- Creating Your First Scene

Everything you record or stream in OBS Studio is built from scenes and sources.

A *scene* is a layout you switch to as a single unit — for example, a "Starting Soon" scene, a "Gameplay" scene, and a "Webcam Only" scene. Each scene is made up of one or more *sources*: individual inputs such as a display capture, a webcam, a microphone, an image, or a browser page.

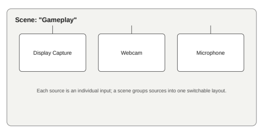

Figure 1: Scene and source relationship

You can reuse the same source across multiple scenes, resize and reposition sources independently within a scene, and switch between scenes instantly while recording or streaming — this is what makes multi-camera or multi-layout setups possible without stopping the recording.

Before building your first scene, see Installing OBS Studio. Once installed, see Creating Your First Scene.

Related tasks

Installing OBS Studio on page 6
Download and install OBS Studio on Windows or macOS.

Creating Your First Scene on page 6
Build a scene with a display capture and a webcam.

Installing OBS Studio

Download and install OBS Studio on Windows or macOS.

The installation steps differ slightly by operating system.

1. Go to `obsproject.com/download` and download the installer for your operating system.
2. Run the downloaded `.exe` installer and follow the setup wizard, accepting the default options.
3. Launch OBS Studio.

   On first launch, the Auto-Configuration Wizard runs and recommends output settings based on your hardware and internet connection. Accepting the recommended settings is a good starting point.

CAUTION: On some systems, screen and audio capture require explicit OS-level permission. If a source appears black or silent, check your operating system's privacy or security settings before troubleshooting further.

Related concepts

Scenes and Sources on page 5

Creating Your First Scene

Build a scene with a display capture and a webcam.

Requires OBS Studio to be installed and running.

1. In the **Scenes** panel, click the **+** button and name the scene, for example **Gameplay**.
2. In the **Sources** panel, click **+** and choose **Display Capture** (Windows/macOS) to capture your full screen.
   A live preview of your screen appears in the scene canvas.
3. Click **+** again and choose **Video Capture Device** to add your webcam.

   Drag the corners of the webcam source in the preview canvas to resize and reposition it, typically into a lower corner of the frame.
4. Click **+** once more and choose **Audio Input Capture** to add your microphone.
5. Speak into your microphone and confirm the level meter in the **Audio Mixer** panel moves.
   Green and yellow indicate a healthy level; the meter turning red means the input is clipping and should be lowered.

Your scene now has a display capture, a webcam, and a microphone, ready to record or stream.

Related concepts

Scenes and Sources on page 5

Chapter 2

Recording

Topics:

Recording a Video

Record your current scene to a local video file.

Requires a scene with at least one source. See Creating Your First Scene.

1. Select the scene you want to record from the **Scenes** panel.
2. Check the **Output** settings before your first recording. See Output Settings Reference for what each option controls.
3. For archival-quality recordings, open **Settings** > **Output**, switch to **Advanced** output mode, and enable **two-pass encoding** if your encoder supports it.

   Two-pass encoding roughly doubles encoding time in exchange for more consistent quality at a given file size; it is unnecessary for most everyday recordings.
4. Click **Start Recording** in the main window.
   A red recording indicator and elapsed-time counter appear at the bottom of the window.
5. When finished, click **Stop Recording**.

The recording is saved to the folder configured in **Settings** > **Output**, using the format set there.

Related reference

Output Settings Reference on page 8
Key options in the **Settings** > **Output** panel, in Advanced output mode.

Common Recording Issues on page 9
Solutions to problems you may see while recording or streaming.

Output Settings Reference

Key options in the **Settings** > **Output** panel, in Advanced output mode.

Recording settings

Reference values for the most commonly adjusted encoder and output settings.

Setting	Typical value	Description
Recording Format	mkv	Container format. `mkv` is recommended during recording because it recovers cleanly if OBS crashes or the recording is interrupted; remux to `mp4` afterward if needed.
Encoder	x264 or hardware (NVENC/ QuickSync/AMF)	Software encoding (x264) gives the best quality per bit but uses more CPU. Hardware encoders use a dedicated chip on the GPU and free up CPU for the game or application being captured.
Rate Control	CBR	Constant Bitrate keeps file size predictable and is required for most streaming platforms; CRF or a quality-based mode is often preferred for local recordings.
Bitrate	8000–12000 Kbps (1080p)	Higher bitrate improves quality but increases file size and, for streaming, requires more stable upload bandwidth.
Keyframe Interval	2 seconds	Most streaming platforms require a keyframe every 2 seconds; leave this at the default unless a platform specifies otherwise.

Related tasks

Recording a Video on page 8
Record your current scene to a local video file.

Common Recording Issues

Solutions to problems you may see while recording or streaming.

Encoding Overloaded warning

Your CPU cannot encode video fast enough, causing dropped frames. Lower the output resolution or frame rate, switch to a faster x264 preset (for example, from `medium` to `veryfast`), or switch to a hardware encoder if available.

Source appears black

Common with Display Capture and Game Capture sources. Confirm the source is not hidden behind another window using exclusive full-screen mode, and check that OBS has screen-recording permission in your operating system's privacy settings.

Audio and video are out of sync

Right-click the affected audio source in the Audio Mixer, choose **Advanced Audio Properties**, and adjust the **Sync Offset** in milliseconds until playback lines up.

Related tasks

Recording a Video on page 8
Record your current scene to a local video file.

Glossary

scene
: A named layout of one or more sources that can be switched to as a single unit while recording or streaming.

source
: A single input added to a scene, such as a display capture, webcam, image, or audio input.

encoder
: The software or hardware component that compresses raw video into a format suitable for saving or streaming, such as x264 (software) or NVENC (hardware).